

UPSC INDIAN POLITY

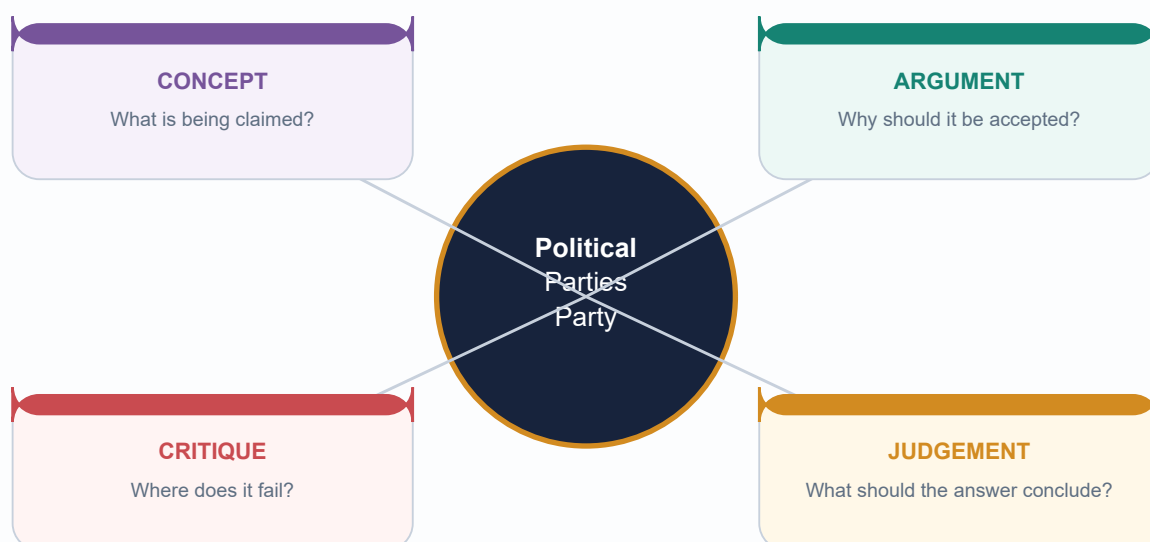
Political Parties & the Party System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE Deep-Learning Visual Notes

Indian Polity · GS Paper II · Prelims + Mains

Layer 1: Basic foundation · Layer 2: Advanced constitutional and exam depth

Sources: Political-Parties.md + 43_Political-Parties.md

Learning cards: 14



Facts from official sources | Inferences clearly marked | No fabricated data

HIGH UPSC RELEVANCE

HIGH

Foundation · Core Foundation

GS-II Indian
Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

greater than **Subject:** Polity · **Tier:** Basic (foundation) · **GS-II***Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.*

STATIC THEORY

• greater than □ = from book · □ = current link · □ = mnemonic. *Deep dive → advanced/43_Political-Parties.md.*

MEMORY HOOK

greater than □ = from book · □ = current link · □ = mnemonic. *Deep dive → advanced/43_Political-Parties.md.*

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. greater than = from book · □ = current link · □ = mnemonic. *Deep dive → advanced/43_Political-Parties.md.*

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Political Parties & the Party System —
ADVANCED / COMPLETE → Core
Foundation

HIGH

Foundation · Snapshot

GS-II Indian
Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Structured comparison from the foundation source layer.

KEY DATA

Item	Fact
Registration	Sec 29A, RPA 1951 (by the ECI)
Categories	National · State · Registered-unrecognised
National-party base	6% votes in 4+ states + 4 LS seats (or alternatives)
Star campaigners	Recognised 40 · unrecognised 20
National parties (2023)	6 — BJP, INC, CPI(M), BSP, NPP, AAP

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Political Parties & the Party System —
ADVANCED / COMPLETE → Snapshot

HIGH

Foundation · Core idea

GS-II Indian
Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

India has a **multi-party system** (largest in the world) that evolved from the "**Congress system**" to competitive coalition politics. The **ECI** grants **national/state** recognition based on **poll performance**, which brings a **reserved symbol** and other privileges.

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

CORE IDEA: RECALL MAP

Core idea

Dimension 1 India has a multi-party system (largest in the world) that evolved from the "Congress system" to competitive coalition politics. The ECI grants nation	Dimension 2 greater than □ National party — any one of: 6% in 4+ states + 4 LS seats · 2% LS seats from 3 states · state party
Dimension 3 greater than in 4 states.	Dimension 4 greater than □ Recognised parties get a reserved symbol + 40 star campaigners; unrecognised pick a free symbol + 20.

STATIC THEORY

- greater than □ **National party** — any one of: **6% in 4+ states + 4 LS seats · 2% LS seats from 3 states · **state party**
- greater than in 4 states**.
- greater than □ Recognised parties get a **reserved symbol + 40 star campaigners**; unrecognised pick a **free symbol + 20**.

MEMORY HOOK

greater than National party — any one of: 6% in 4+ states + 4 LS seats · 2% LS seats from 3 states · state party | greater than Recognised parties get a reserved symbol + 40 star campaigners; unrecognised pick a free symbol** + 20.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Political Parties & the Party System —
ADVANCED / COMPLETE → Core idea

HIGH

Foundation · Must-Know Facts

GS-II Indian
Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

- Registered under **Section 29A of the RPA, 1951**.

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MUST-KNOW FACTS: RECALL MAP

Must-Know Facts

Dimension 1 ☐ Registered under Section 29A of the RPA, 1951.	Dimension 2 ☐ Rajni Kothari → "one-party dominance / Congress system."
Dimension 3 ☐ Recognition privileges: reserved symbol, broadcast time, one proposer, electoral-roll access.	

STATIC THEORY

- ☐ Rajni Kothari → "one-party dominance / Congress system."
- ☐ Recognition privileges: reserved symbol, broadcast time, one proposer, electoral-roll access.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Registered under **Section 29A of the RPA, 1951**.
2. Rajni Kothari → "one-party dominance / Congress system."
3. Recognition privileges: reserved symbol, broadcast time, one proposer, electoral-roll access.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Political Parties & the Party System —
 ADVANCED / COMPLETE → Must-Know
 Facts

HIGH

Foundation • ☐ Current linkGS-II Indian
Polity

NEWS TRIGGER

☐ **Electoral Bonds struck down** by the SC (**ADR case, Feb 2024**) as unconstitutional (right to information). **ECI orders of 10 Apr 2023** made AAP a national party and withdrew national status from TMC, NCP and CPI; **official list checked 21 Jul 2026: six national parties**. The RTI/inner-party-democracy debate continues.

INTRO & ORIGIN

Exam-ready treatment of ☐ Current link.

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Political Parties & the Party System —
 ADVANCED / COMPLETE → ☐ Current link

HIGH

Advanced • Core Foundation

GS-II Indian
Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

greater than **Subject:** Polity • **Tier:** Advanced (exam depth) • **GS Paper:** GS-II

Advanced learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

CORE FOUNDATION: RECALL MAP

Core Foundation

Dimension 1

greater than **Subject:** Polity • **Tier:** Advanced (exam depth) •
GS Paper: GS-II

Dimension 2

greater than **Grounded in:** Indian Polity by M. Laxmikant, Ch. 69 and electoral-reforms section (direct check of the local Sixth Revised Edition PDF) +

Dimension 3

greater than □ = from source book • □□ = inference / analysis
• □ = ECI/court-verified update.

Dimension 4

greater than **Companion:** basic/Political-Parties.md.

STATIC THEORY

• greater than **Grounded in:** Indian Polity by M. Laxmikant, Ch. 69 and electoral-reforms section (direct check of the local Sixth Revised Edition PDF) + ECI update.

• greater than □ = from source book • □□ = inference / analysis • □ = ECI/court-verified update.

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MUST-KNOW FACTS

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MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Political Parties & the Party System —
ADVANCED / COMPLETE → Core
Foundation

HIGH

Advanced • PART A — FEATURES OF THE INDIAN PARTY SYSTEM □

GS-II Indian
Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

□ **Multi-party system** — India has the **largest number of parties** in the world.

Advanced learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

PART A — FEATURES OF THE INDIAN PARTY SYSTEM □: RECALL MAP

PART A — FEATURES OF THE INDIAN PARTY SYSTEM □

Dimension 1 □ Multi-party system — India has the largest number of parties in the world.	Dimension 2 □ One-dominant-party system — Rajni Kothari's "Congress system" (declined post-1967).
Dimension 3 □ Lack of clear ideology (except BJP, CPI, CPM); personality cult; parties based on religion/caste/language.	Dimension 4 □ Emergence of regional parties; factions & defections; lack of an effective Opposition.

STATIC THEORY

- □ **One-dominant-party system** — Rajni Kothari's "**Congress system**" (declined post-1967).
- □ **Lack of clear ideology** (except BJP, CPI, CPM); **personality cult**; parties based on **religion/caste/language**.
- □ **Emergence of regional parties; factions & defections; lack of an effective Opposition.**

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. **Multi-party system** — India has the **largest number of parties** in the world.
2. **One-dominant-party system** — Rajni Kothari's "**Congress system**" (declined post-1967).
3. **Lack of clear ideology** (except BJP, CPI, CPM); **personality cult**; parties based on **religion/caste/language**.
4. **Emergence of regional parties; factions & defections; lack of an effective Opposition.**

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Political Parties & the Party System —
 ADVANCED / COMPLETE → PART A —
 FEATURES OF THE INDIAN PARTY
 SYSTEM □

HIGH

Advanced · PART B — RECOGNITION: NATIONAL vs STATE PARTIES □ □

GS-II Indian
Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

- The **Election Commission** registers parties (**Sec 29A, RPA 1951**) and grants **national/state** recognition on **poll performance**; the rest are **registered-unrecognised**.

Advanced learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. The **Election Commission** registers parties (**Sec 29A, RPA 1951**) and grants **national/state** recognition on **poll performance**; the rest are **registered-unrecognised**.

MAINS ANGLE**STUDY LINK**

Political Parties & the Party System —
ADVANCED / COMPLETE → PART B —
RECOGNITION: NATIONAL vs STATE
PARTIES □□

HIGH**Advanced · Privileges of recognition** □GS-II Indian
Polity**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Reserved symbol; **one proposer** for nomination; **broadcast time** on state media; access to electoral rolls.

Advanced learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

STATIC THEORY

• **Star campaigners**: recognised = **40**, registered-unrecognised = **20** (their travel not counted in candidate expenditure).

MAINS ANGLE**STUDY LINK**

Political Parties & the Party System —
ADVANCED / COMPLETE → Privileges of
recognition □

HIGH**Advanced · National party — any ONE condition** □GS-II Indian
Polity**INTRO & ORIGIN**

6% valid votes in **4+ states** (LS or Assembly) + **4 LS seats** (from any states); **OR**

Advanced learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

NATIONAL PARTY — ANY ONE CONDITION □: RECALL MAP**National party — any ONE condition** □

Dimension 1 6% valid votes in 4+ states (LS or Assembly) + 4 LS seats (from any states); OR	Dimension 2 2% of LS seats, with members from 3 states; OR
Dimension 3 Recognised as a state party in 4 states.	

STATIC THEORY

• **2% of LS seats**, with members from **3 states**; **OR**

• Recognised as a **state party** in **4 states**.

MAINS ANGLE**STUDY LINK**

Political Parties & the Party System —
 ADVANCED / COMPLETE → National party
 — any ONE condition □

HIGH**Advanced · State party — any ONE condition □**GS-II Indian
Polity**INTRO & ORIGIN**

6% votes in the state (Assembly) + 2 Assembly seats; OR

Advanced learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

STATE PARTY — ANY ONE CONDITION □: RECALL MAP

State party — any ONE condition □

Dimension 1 6% votes in the state (Assembly) + 2 Assembly seats; OR	Dimension 2 6% votes (LS from state) + 1 LS seat; OR
Dimension 3 3% of Assembly seats or 3 seats (whichever more); OR	Dimension 4 1 LS seat per 25 LS seats allotted to the state; OR

STATIC THEORY

- **6% votes (LS from state) + 1 LS seat; OR**
- **3% of Assembly seats or 3 seats** (whichever more); **OR**
- **1 LS seat per 25 LS seats** allotted to the state; **OR**
- **8% of total valid votes in the state (LS or Assembly) — added in 2011.**

MAINS ANGLE**STUDY LINK**

Political Parties & the Party System —
 ADVANCED / COMPLETE → State party —
 any ONE condition □

HIGH**Advanced · UPSC Traps**GS-II Indian
Polity**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Exam-ready treatment of UPSC Traps.

Advanced learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Parties are registered under the Constitution

CORRECT: registered under **Sec 29A, RPA 1951** (a statute).

WRONG: National-party status needs 6% votes in all states

CORRECT: **6% in any 4+ states + 4 LS seats** (or the alternatives).

WRONG: Recognised & unrecognised parties get the same star campaigners

CORRECT: **40 vs 20.**

WRONG: A "national party" contests only national elections

CORRECT: the label is about **recognition/privileges**, not where it contests.

WRONG: The EC allots a symbol to unrecognised parties too

CORRECT: they pick from **free symbols**; only recognised parties get **reserved** symbols.

MAINS ANGLE**STUDY LINK**

Political Parties & the Party System —
ADVANCED / COMPLETE → UPSC Traps

HIGH**Advanced • □ CA hooks (ECI/court-verified)**GS-II Indian
Polity**NEWS TRIGGER**

□ □ **Electoral Bonds struck down** — SC in **Association for Democratic Reforms (Feb 2024)** held the 2018 Electoral Bond Scheme **unconstitutional** (violates the **right to information, Art 19(1)(a)**); ordered the SBI to disclose donor data. □ □ **ECI orders dated 10 Apr 2023:** AAP gained national-party status; TMC,

INTRO & ORIGIN

NCP and CPI lost it. **Status checked 21 Jul 2026 against ECI's notified list:** six national parties — BJP, INC, CPI(M), BSP, NPP and AAP.

Advanced learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

□ **CA HOOKS (ECI/COURT-VERIFIED): RECALL MAP**□ **CA hooks (ECI/court-verified)****Dimension 1**

NCP and CPI lost it. Status checked 21 Jul 2026 against ECI's notified list: six national parties — BJP, INC, CPI(M), BSP, NPP and AAP.

Dimension 2

□ Debate on bringing parties under the RTI Act (CIC held 6 national parties are "public authorities," 2013 — not

Dimension 3

complied with) and inner-party democracy / criminalisation of politics.

STATIC THEORY

- Debate on bringing parties under the **RTI Act** (CIC held 6 national parties are "public authorities," 2013 — not
- complied with) and **inner-party democracy** / criminalisation of politics.

MAINS ANGLE**STUDY LINK**

Political Parties & the Party System —
 ADVANCED / COMPLETE → ☐ CA hooks
 (ECI/court-verified)

HIGH**Advanced · Mains angles**GS-II Indian
Polity**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Exam-ready treatment of Mains angles.

Advanced learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MAINS ANGLE

"Money power and opacity threaten Indian democracy." Discuss in light of the Electoral Bonds verdict. Should political parties be brought under the RTI Act? Examine transparency vs autonomy. Regionalisation of the party system: a strength of federal democracy or a source of instability?

STUDY LINK

Political Parties & the Party System —
 ADVANCED / COMPLETE → Mains angles

 End of Register Notes — UPSC Agent / Copilot CLI